

Reward Centers

The brain's reward system evolved because it helped us seek out things that are important for our survival. But if this system is hijacked, it can lead to addiction.

Reward pathways

When we do something that is important for our survival, such as eating when hungry, or having sex, neurons that trigger the release of the neurotransmitter dopamine are activated in the ventral tegmental area (VTA). These send signals to an area called the nucleus accumbens—a rush in dopamine here tells the brain this is a behavior that should be repeated. Neurons also send signals to the frontal cortex, which focuses attention on the beneficial activity.

